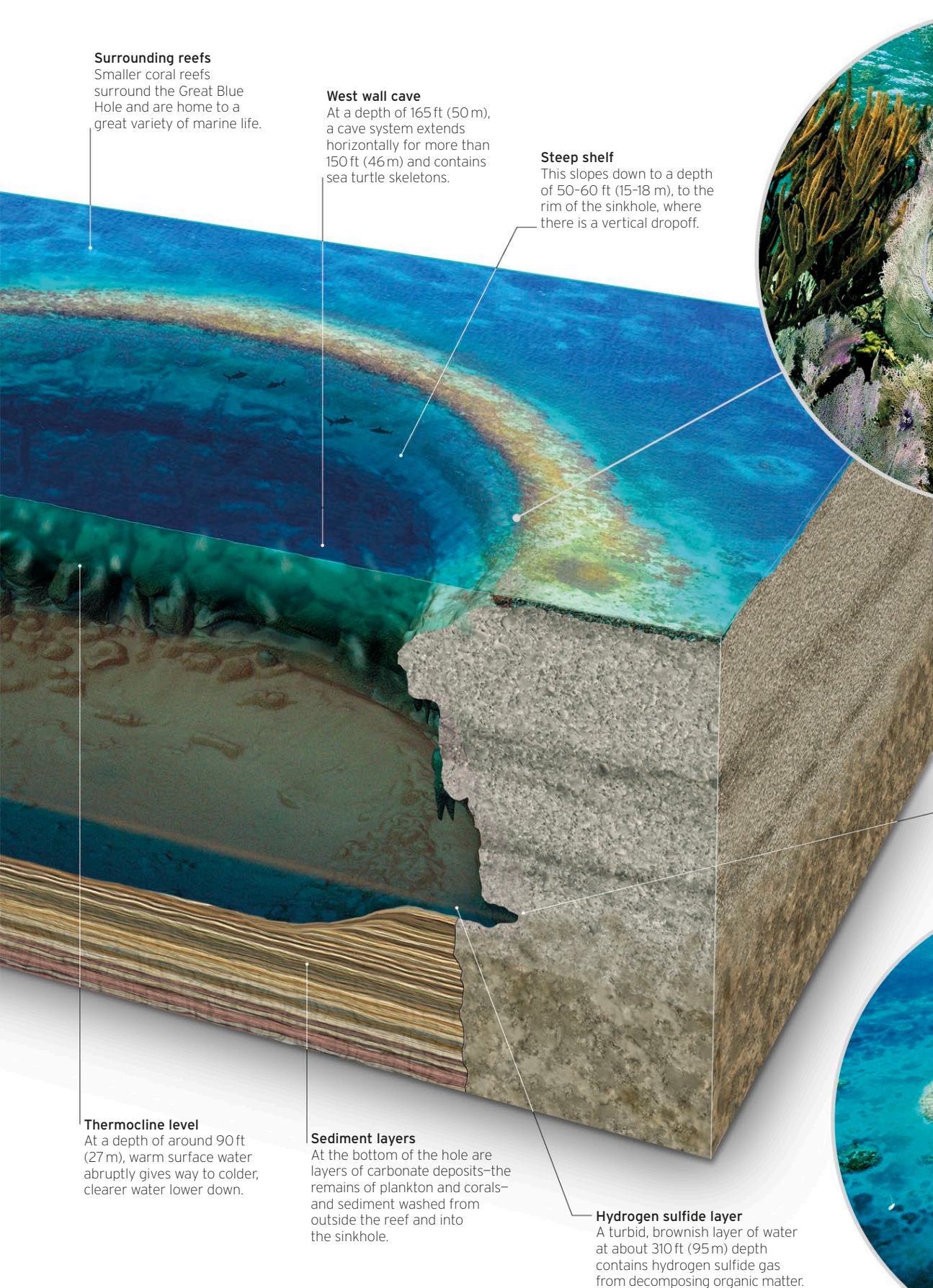




Surrounding reefs
Smaller coral reefs surround the Great Blue Hole and are home to a great variety of marine life.

West wall cave
At a depth of 165 ft (50 m), a cave system extends horizontally for more than 150 ft (46 m) and contains sea turtle skeletons.

Steep shelf
This slopes down to a depth of 50–60 ft (15–18 m), to the rim of the sinkhole, where there is a vertical dropoff.



△ CORAL RESERVE
The rim of the hole, close to the surface, is covered in a profuse array of both stony, reef-building corals (hexacorals), such as brain coral, and many colorful soft corals (octocorals).

Notch
This indentation is the result of dissolved hydrogen sulfide in the water at the bottom of the hole dissolving the limestone walls.



△ GIANT SINKHOLE
Like the pupil of an eye, the blue hole appears from above as a dark inky-blue circle. This contrasts with the mottled turquoise shades of the surrounding shallow water covering Lighthouse Reef.

Thermocline level
At a depth of around 90 ft (27 m), warm surface water abruptly gives way to colder, clearer water lower down.

Sediment layers
At the bottom of the hole are layers of carbonate deposits—the remains of plankton and corals—and sediment washed from outside the reef and into the sinkhole.

Hydrogen sulfide layer
A turbid, brownish layer of water at about 310 ft (95 m) depth contains hydrogen sulfide gas from decomposing organic matter.

Stalactites hanging over the entrance to a cave on the sinkhole's wall are up to **25 ft (8 m) long**